

THE OLDEST  
**MEXICAN**  
RED-KNEED  
TARANTULA  
IS KNOWN  
TO **HAVE**  
**LIVED FOR**

**20**  
**YEARS**



**GOLIATH**  
TARANTULA  
**FANGS CAN**  
GROW UP TO

**1 1/2 IN**

**(3.8 CM)**

#### Western desert tarantula

One of the largest spiders in North America, this desert species from Arizona and Mexico survives heat and drought by burrowing underground.

#### Mexican red-kneed tarantula

Found in tropical hill forests, this species burrows into banks and around tree roots. A popular pet, it is now threatened by illegal trade.

#### Mighty spiders

Tarantulas grow bigger and live longer than other spiders. In most parts of the tropics they are high in the food chain. But their numbers are small wherever they live, making them vulnerable to habitat destruction.

#### Goliath tarantula

The biggest tarantula—and heaviest spider of them all—lives in the rainforests of the Amazon basin. It has a leg span of 12 in (30 cm).

#### Chaco golden-kneed tarantula

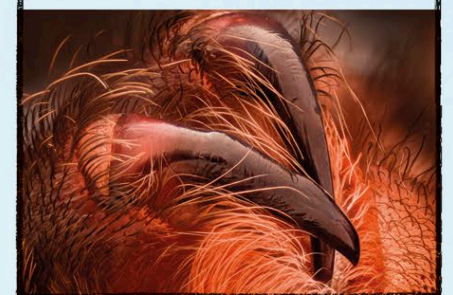
The Chaco is an area of extensive grassland in South America, south of the Amazon, and the golden-kneed is one of many tarantula species that thrive in this habitat.

#### Blue-footed baboon spider

Baboon spiders are ground-living tarantulas found in Africa. They get their name from their wide-tipped legs, which are said to resemble the fingers of a baboon.

#### Venomous fangs

Spiders use their fangs to inject venom that disables their prey. Tarantula venom can be deadly to small creatures, but is usually no more serious to a human than a bee sting.



# Tarantulas

Many big spiders are called “tarantulas,” but all true tarantulas have fat hairy bodies and belong to a family called the theraphosids. Found in all warm parts of the world, there are nearly 1,000 species: the smallest is no bigger than your thumb, but the biggest can span a large dinner plate with its legs.